Kitchen Booking Workflow

Process Walkthrough — n8n Automation

Milestone 1 Deliverable · Version 1.0 · 2026-04-14

This guide walks a non-technical reader through exactly what happens when someone books the kitchen. It can be narrated over screenshots for a training video or reviewed as a PDF handout.

> **Audience:** Operations staff, HR, and anyone onboarding to the kitchen booking process. No coding knowledge required.

Scene 1 — A Guest Chef Submits a Booking

Chef Amara is visiting next Tuesday to cook a tasting menu. She fills in the booking form on the intranet.

Form data submitted:

- Name: *Amara Okafor*
- Visitor type: **Guest Chef**
- Start time: *Tue 21 Apr 2026, 18:00*
- End time: *Tue 21 Apr 2026, 21:00*
- Purpose: *Spring tasting menu*

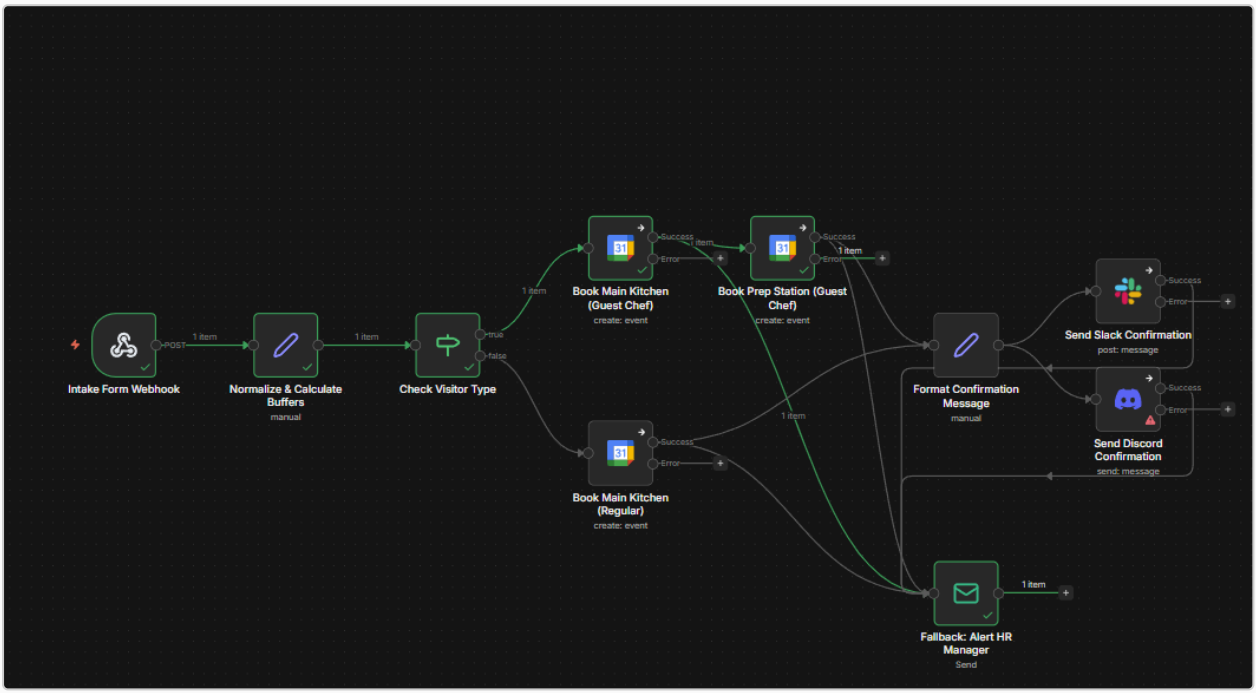
When she clicks **Submit**, the form sends the details to our n8n workflow over the internet.

[Screenshot: Intranet booking form with Guest Chef option selected]

Scene 2 — The Workflow Wakes Up

The workflow is always listening on a web address (the Webhook). The moment Amara's form arrives, the first node lights up green.

Full canvas — Webhook receiving the booking and dispatching through the graph.



The workflow now has Amara's request in memory and is ready to decide what to do with it.

Scene 3 — The Conditional Logic Fires

A decision node called **Check Visitor Type** inspects the `visitorType` field.

- If it says `Guest Chef`, the request follows the **top path**.
- If it says `Regular`, it follows the **bottom path**.

Because Amara is a Guest Chef, the workflow takes the top path.

> **Why this matters:** Guest Chefs need extra equipment and prep space. Regulars do not. Sending them down different paths keeps the calendars tidy.

Scene 4 — Calculating the Buffer Times

Because Amara is a Guest Chef, the **Normalize & Calculate Buffers** node adjusts her times:

- **Prep buffer:** 60 minutes are *subtracted* from her start time. The calendar booking begins at **17:00** (not 18:00) so she can set up.
- **Cleanup buffer:** 30 minutes are *added* to her end time. The booking ends at **21:30** so staff can clean.

Field	Submitted	After Buffer
Start time	18:00	**17:00**
End time	21:00	**21:30**

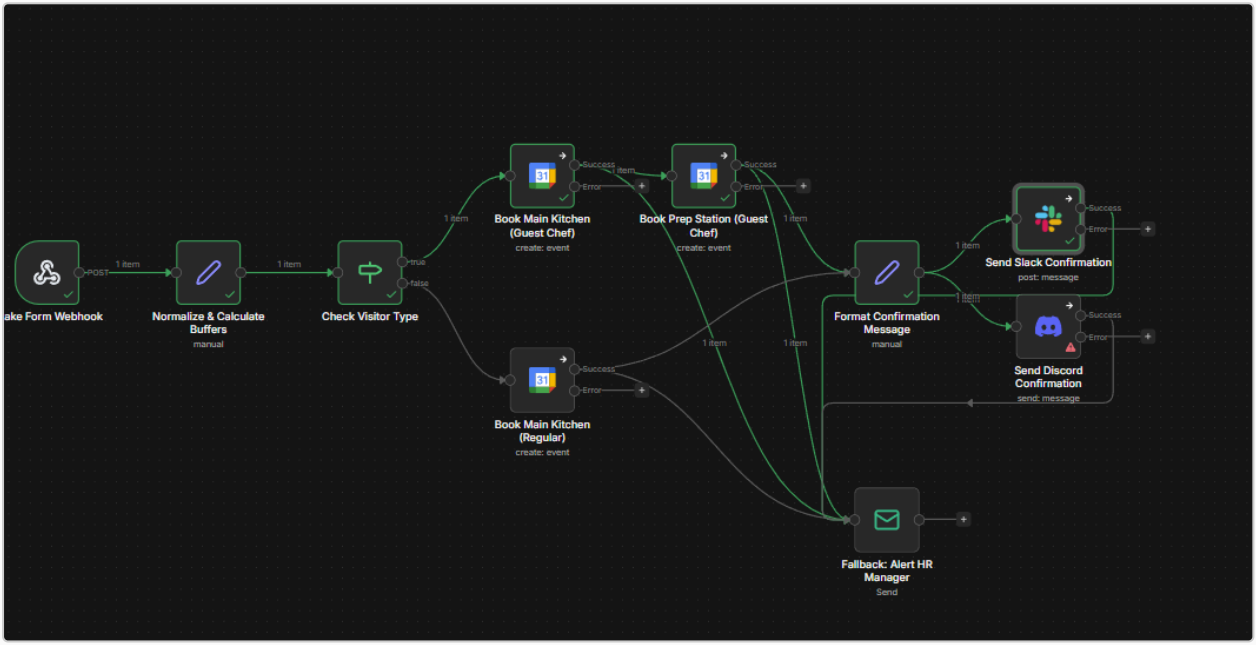
> **Note:** Regulars skip this logic. Their submitted times are used as-is.

Scene 5 — Booking Two Calendars

A Guest Chef needs **both** the Main Kitchen and the Prep Station. The workflow runs two calendar nodes in sequence on the Guest Chef branch:

1. **Main Kitchen calendar** — creates an event titled "*Guest Chef: Amara Okafor — Spring tasting menu*" from 17:00 to 21:30.
2. **Prep Station calendar** — creates the same event on the prep-station calendar.

Slack + Discord notification stage (canvas view).



> **For Regulars:** Only the Main Kitchen calendar is booked. The Prep Station step is skipped.

Scene 6 — Announcing to Slack and Discord

After the calendar events are created, the **Format Confirmation Message** node builds a human-readable summary. Two messages are then sent in parallel to the **#kitchen-updates** channel:

- **Slack:** a formatted card with Amara's name, times, and purpose.
- **Discord:** the same information, posted via webhook.

> New Guest Chef booking confirmed
> Chef: Amara Okafor
> When: Tue 21 Apr 2026, 17:00 – 21:30 (includes 60 min prep + 30 min cleanup)
> Purpose: Spring tasting menu
> Calendars: Main Kitchen, Prep Station

The team now knows the kitchen is claimed.

Scene 7 — Regular Visitor, the Shorter Path

For comparison, here is what happens for a Regular visitor (e.g., staff booking the kitchen for a Friday lunch-and-learn):

1. Webhook receives the form.
2. **Check Visitor Type** returns `false` → follow the bottom path.
3. **No buffer** is applied; submitted times are kept exactly.
4. **Only the Main Kitchen calendar** is booked.
5. Slack and Discord receive a shorter confirmation message.

Scene 8 — The Error Path: When Something Breaks

Imagine the Google Calendar API is down, or a credential expired overnight.

1. The **Main Kitchen** calendar node tries to create the event.
2. The API returns an error (`401 Unauthorized` or `503 Service Unavailable`).
3. Instead of stopping silently, the node's **error output** routes to the **Fallback: Alert HR Manager** email node.
4. The Email node immediately sends an **urgent message to the HR Manager**.

> **Subject:** URGENT: Kitchen Booking Failure
>
> A kitchen booking failed to complete.
> • Visitor: Amara Okafor (Guest Chef)
> • Requested: Tue 21 Apr 2026, 18:00 – 21:00
> • Failing step: Book Main Kitchen (Guest Chef)
> • Error: 401 Unauthorized — credential expired
>
> Please follow up with the visitor and investigate the integration.

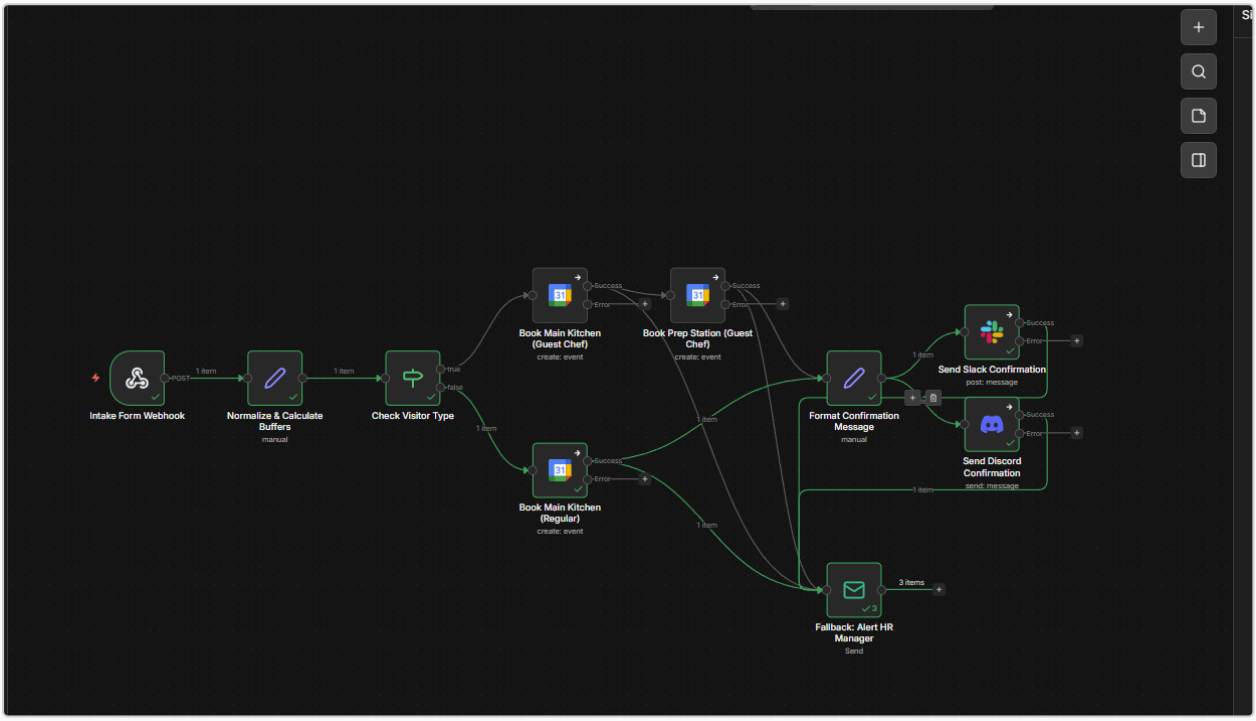
> **Important:** This email is sent *in addition to* any logging. HR is the human fallback so that no booking silently disappears. Verified in test: SMTP returned `250 2.0.0 OK`, accepted by the HR recipient.

Milestone 2 — Live Evidence the Workflow Works

The screenshots below were captured from the live n8n instance after credentials were wired for Google Calendar, Slack, Discord, and SMTP. Every external integration delivered successfully.

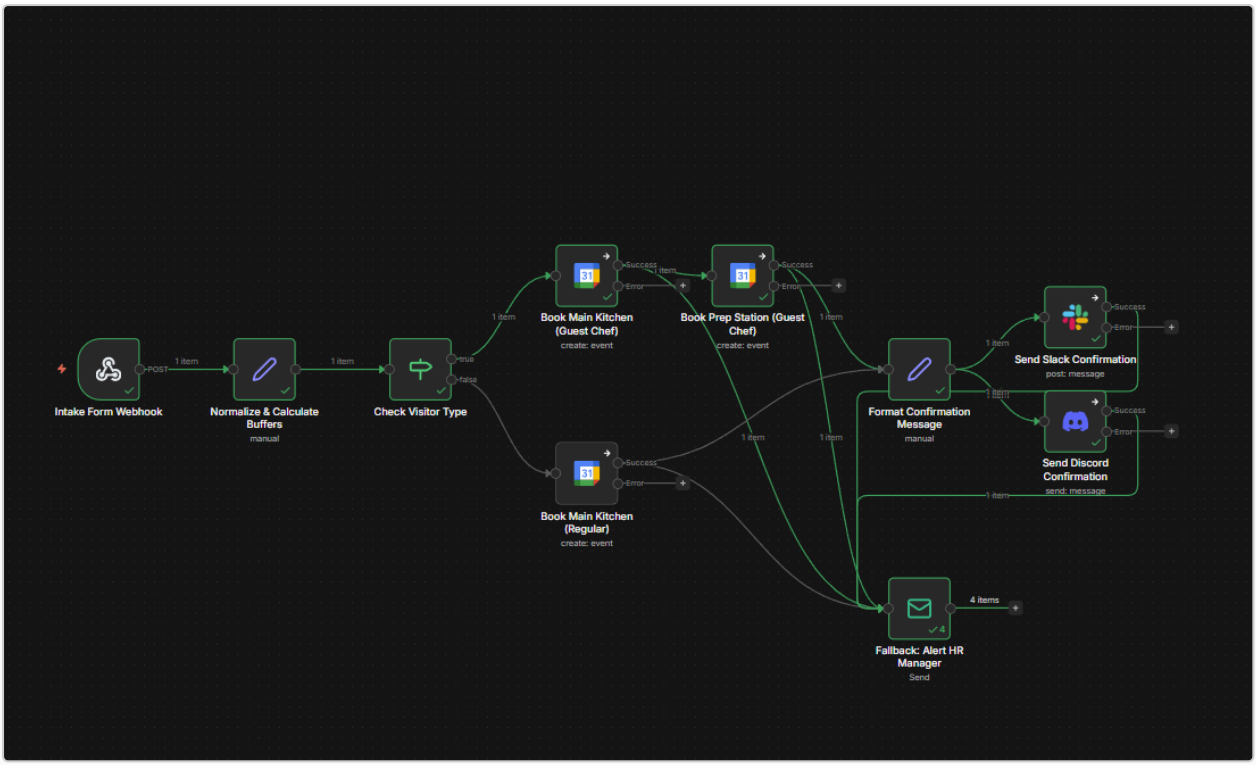
Full canvas — all nodes green (both branches executed)

Execution trail with 3 items aggregated at the HR fallback sink — confirms error edges are wired to every external node.



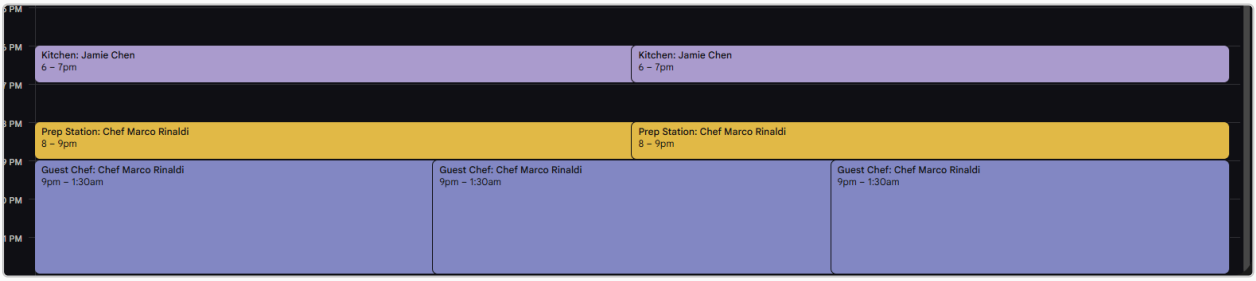
Guest Chef branch fired

IF → buffered Set → dual Google Calendar → merge → Slack + Discord. 4 items reached the HR sink across runs.



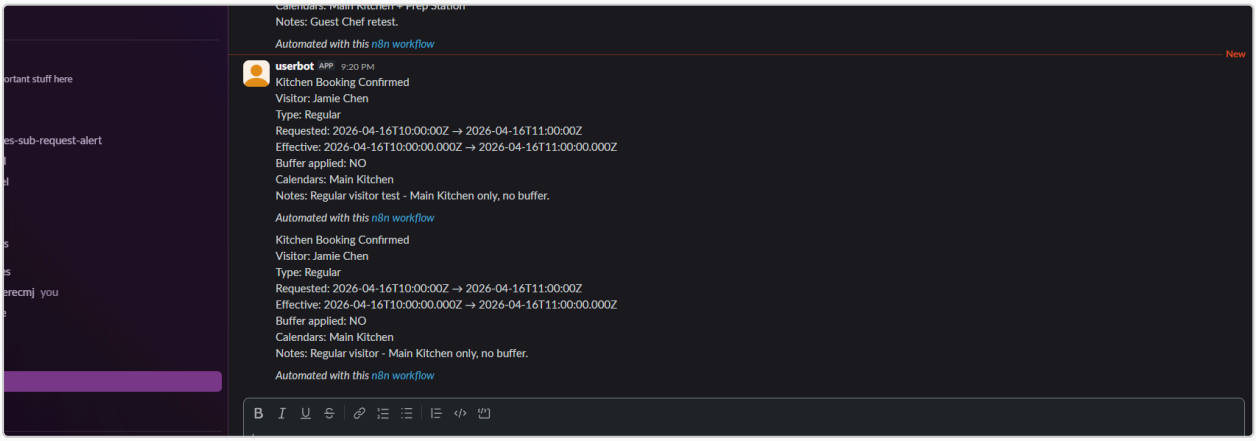
Real Google Calendar events created

Regular: "Kitchen: Jamie Chen 6–7pm" — single event, no buffer. Guest Chef: "Prep Station: Chef Marco Rinaldi 8–9pm" plus "Guest Chef: Chef Marco Rinaldi 9pm–1:30am" — dual calendar with buffered times.



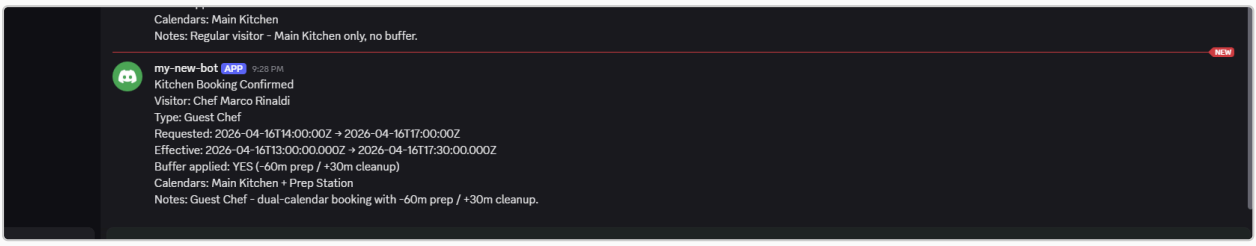
Slack posts in #kitchen-updates

Confirmation cards for both Regular and Guest Chef — showing Requested, Effective, and Buffer-applied fields.



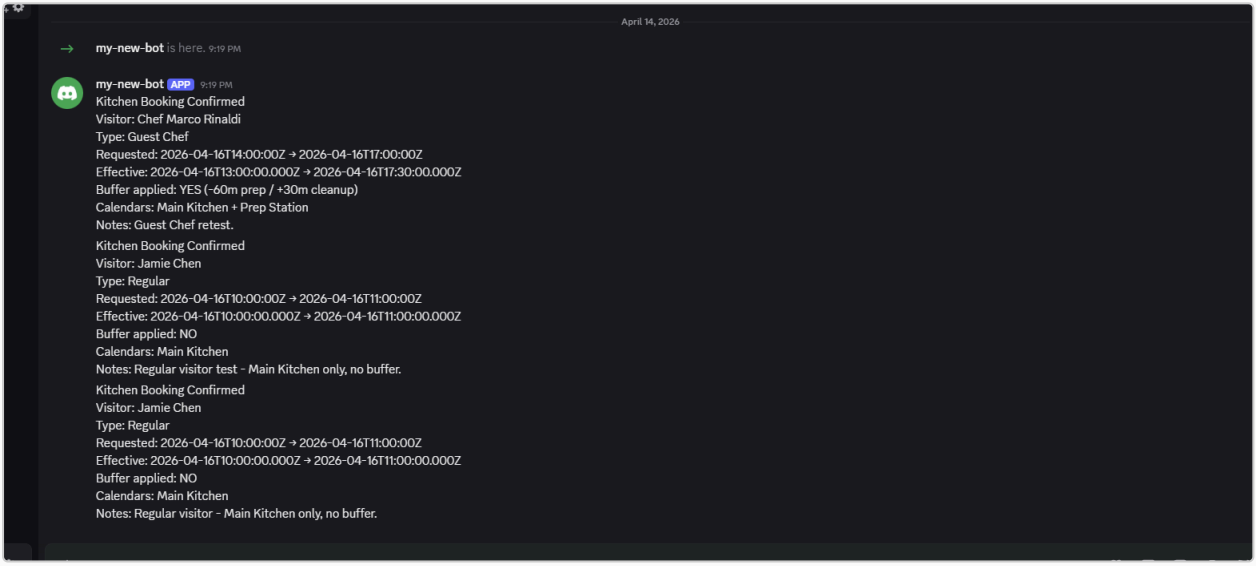
Guest Chef Slack card (buffer visible)

"Buffer applied: YES (-60m prep / +30m cleanup)" and "Calendars: Main Kitchen + Prep Station" — proves the conditional logic path.



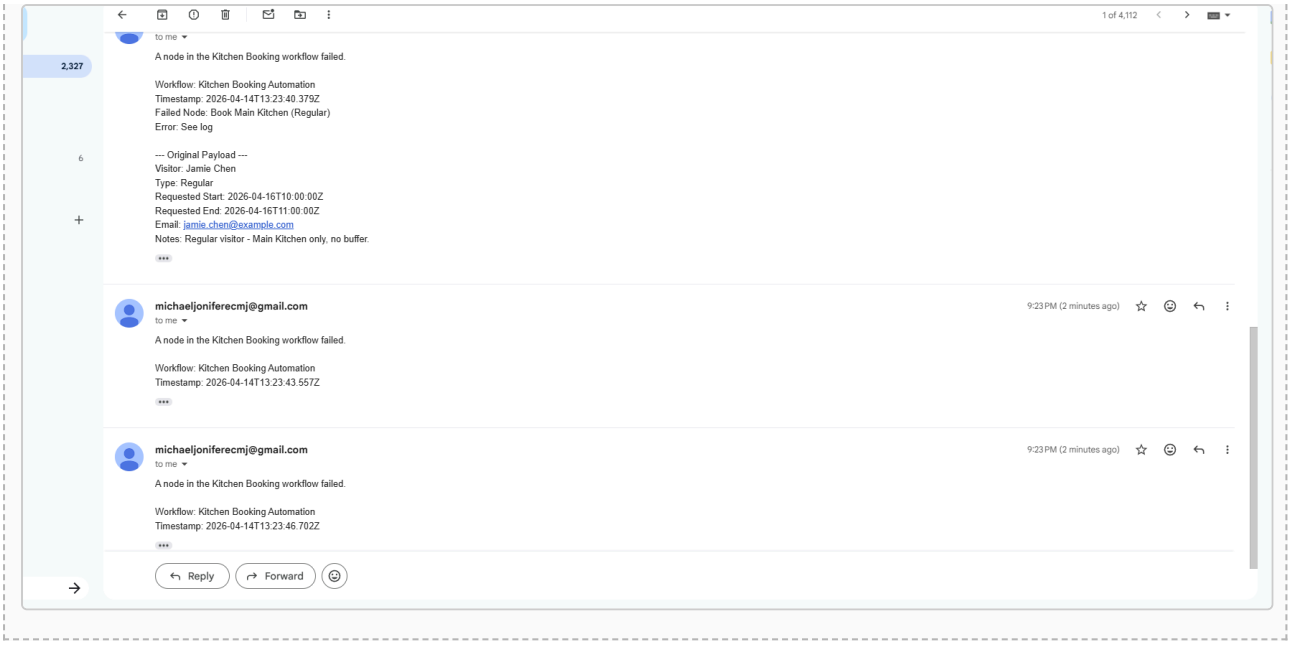
Discord posts in Kitchen Updates

Identical content posted to Discord via webhook.



HR urgent email — real inbox

Subject line triggered by the fallback node. Body includes Workflow, Timestamp, Failed Node, and the original Payload.


1 of 4,112
2,327
6
to me
A node in the Kitchen Booking workflow failed.
Workflow: Kitchen Booking Automation
Timestamp: 2026-04-14T13:23:40.379Z
Failed Node: Book Main Kitchen (Regular)
Error: See log
--- Original Payload ---
Visitor: Jamie Chen
Type: Regular
Requested Start: 2026-04-16T10:00:00Z
Requested End: 2026-04-16T11:00:00Z
Email: jamie.chen@example.com
Notes: Regular visitor - Main Kitchen only, no buffer.
michaeljoniferecmj@gmail.com
9:23 PM (2 minutes ago)
to me
A node in the Kitchen Booking workflow failed.
Workflow: Kitchen Booking Automation
Timestamp: 2026-04-14T13:23:43.557Z
michaeljoniferecmj@gmail.com
9:23 PM (2 minutes ago)
to me
A node in the Kitchen Booking workflow failed.
Workflow: Kitchen Booking Automation
Timestamp: 2026-04-14T13:23:46.702Z
Reply
Forward

Recap — What You Just Saw

1. A form submission arrives.
2. The workflow decides: Guest Chef or Regular?
3. Guest Chefs get extra buffer time automatically.
4. The right calendars are booked (one or two).
5. Slack and Discord are notified.
6. If anything breaks, HR gets an urgent email.

Total time from form submission to team notification: **under 5 seconds**.

Where to Go Next

- To understand *why* each decision exists, read `LOGIC_FLOW.md`.
- To set up or test the workflow yourself, read `README.md`.
- To see test data used for validation, open `sample-data/test-bookings.csv`.